The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Spc. Nicole Miller

The **Pentagon** is reportedly preparing to deploy more than 1,000 combat troops to the Middle East, though America has apparently not made the decision to put boots on the ground in **Iran**. According to the *Wall Street Journal*, the forces are from a rapid-response brigade within the army's 82nd Airborne Division, and can deploy within a day. Israel, meanwhile, said it would occupy a swathe of southern **Lebanon**.

Iran said it would let "non-hostile vessels" pass through the **Strait of Hormuz** "in co-ordination" with Iranian authorities, according to reports of a letter sent to the International Maritime Organisation. Earlier the regime named Mohammad Bagher Zolghadr, a retired commander of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, as head of Iran's Supreme National Security Council.

Arm will start selling its own chips for the first time. Until now the chip designer licensed blueprints to companies that produce chips, such as Nvidia and Google, and took a cut from the sale. Arm said the chip, named AGI CPU, would be used to power data centres more efficiently; Meta and OpenAI will be among its customers.

A jury in New Mexico ruled that **Meta** violated the state's consumer-protection rules by misleading users about child safety

on its social-media platforms, and ordered it to pay $375m in civil penalties. Meta said it would appeal against the ruling. The tech giant is defending its handling of its young users' mental health in a separate trial that alleges its platforms were designed to be addictive.

Russian drone and missile strikes across **Ukraine** killed at least five people. The south-eastern city of Zaporizhia was one of the worst affected. Ukrainian intelligence officials have said that Russia is planning a new ground offensive. The Institute for the Study of War, a think-tank, assesses that Russia began its spring offensive on Saturday.

NASA announced revamped plans for returning astronauts to the **Moon** by 2028. Jared Isaacman, NASA's new head, said construction of a lunar space station had been "paused"; instead a $20bn base would be built on the Moon's surface. NASA envisions frequent landings and more reliance on private-sector providers such as SpaceX or Blue Origin. China is meanwhile racing to land astronauts on the Moon by 2030.

Mohamed Salah is leaving **Liverpool Football Club** at the end of the current season of the Premier League. Since signing to Liverpool in 2017 Mr Salah, the "Egyptian King", has scored 255 goals across 435 match appearances, making him the club's third-highest goalscorer. In December Mr Salah said he had been "thrown under the bus" by the club after repeatedly being left on the bench.

Figure of the day: 1926, the last year a living American president was put on a coin. Read about why Donald Trump also wants to put his face on money.

Photograph: AP

Donald Trump shifts gears on Iran

Having spent the weekend issuing dire threats against Iran's regime, on Monday Donald Trump changed tack. He posted on social media that he was suspending strikes against Iran's power plants and energy infrastructure. Furthermore, he announced that he was in talks with Iran (denied by the Iranians themselves) to achieve the "COMPLETE AND TOTAL RESOLUTION OF OUR HOSTILITIES". Big questions remain: is this a prelude to Mr Trump bailing out altogether, or the cue for more negotiations? And where does this leave America's ally, Israel?

Increasingly, Mr Trump's focus seems to be on averting a global energy crisis. Israel thus faces the prospect of the war ending without reaching its key objective of provoking a popular uprising to topple the Iranian regime. Instead, it is looking more likely that the ill-judged campaign will end messily, with an Iran that is damaged, but still able to inflict considerable damage on the region and the world.

Photograph: Reuters

Continental drift in Denmark’s election

Mette Frederiksen, Denmark’s prime minister, hoped that a snap general election on Tuesday would let her bank support for standing up to President Donald Trump’s threats to seize Greenland, a Danish territory. But even a Trump bump might not stop her party suffering its worst result in more than a century. Polls suggest Ms Frederiksen’s Social Democrats will get 21% of the vote, compared with 28% in 2022. Other parties in her governing coalition are also projected to suffer heavy losses.

Among the big winners will be parties from the populist left and right. The Danish People’s Party, a populist right-wing party, is projected to get 10% of the vote, up from less than 3%. The Green Left is projected to increase its share of the vote from 8% to almost 14%. This would leave both the left and right blocs a hair’s breadth from a majority and wooing the most likely kingmaker, the centrist Moderate party.

Photograph: Reuters

Xiaomi the money

After years of exceptional growth China’s auto sales have been sluggish at the start of 2026. In February passenger-car sales fell by 26% year on year and 33% month on month. This is probably because many subsidies for electric vehicles expired at the end of last year. But another subsidy is never too far away in China’s consumer market, and some are now being renewed. This, analysts say, should help revive growth.

To understand how individual companies fared last year, take a look at Xiaomi, a fresh entrant to the EV market. The company, one of China’s most successful smartphone and consumer-device makers, reported on Tuesday that its quarterly profit fell for the first time in three years in 2025. Lei Jun, Xiaomi’s charismatic founder, said that the company may have to eventually increase prices. That may help it cover its costs—but will make it that much harder to finally pick up enough demand for its sleek EVs.

What's next?

Xiaomi, market capitalisation, $bn

Source: LSEG Workspace

Photograph: Reuters

Anthropic fights back against the Pentagon

On Tuesday a judge in California will hear a request by Anthropic, an AI lab, to put a preliminary halt to efforts by the Trump administration to blacklist it from government contracts and declare it a supply-chain risk. Anthropic will argue that the crackdown is illegal retaliation for its efforts to build safe AI. Led by the Pentagon, the government will counter that Anthropic is not a trusted partner and that it poses an unacceptable national-security risk.

The case stems from Anthropic's refusal to remove safeguards from its AI tools that prevent them being used for autonomous weapons and mass surveillance. But it will hinge on whether the judge decides that a draconian measure only previously applied to foreign adversaries is suitable for a contract dispute with an American firm. Lawyers, former generals and Microsoft, a tech giant, have weighed in on Anthropic's behalf, arguing that the Pentagon has gone too far.

Photograph: Reuters

Can Ilia Malinin pick himself up?

Perhaps the biggest shock of the Winter Olympics last month was Ilia Malinin's failure to win individual gold in figure skating. The American had won the previous two world championships and has pushed the sport's technical boundaries. In 2022, aged just 17, he was the first person to land a quad axel—a four-and-a-half turn jump—in a competition. But at the Olympics his choice of a difficult routine hurt him. He fell twice in his final skate and finished eighth. His rivals beat him by performing simpler tricks with greater accuracy.

The "Quad God" attributed his poor performance to the pressure of high expectations. "It just felt so overwhelming," he said. He has a chance to put things right at the World Championships, which began in Prague on Tuesday. Mikhail Shaidorov of Kazakhstan, who won the Olympic gold, is skipping the event. That may make Mr Malinin's quest a bit easier.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Clover, buckwheat and manuka are types of what food product?

Monday: Which 1971 album by Joni Mitchell is often rated as one of the greatest of all time?

Have nothing in your house that you do not know to be useful, or believe to be beautiful.

William Morris